



# PHYSICAL THERAPIST

## JOB DESCRIPTION

Physical therapists play a vital part in treating people with physical difficulties resulting from injury, illness, disability, or aging. A physical therapist uses treatments including massage, hydrotherapy, and exercise to help patients recover or manage their condition. They may work in private practices, or in hospitals alongside other health care experts, such as doctors, nurses, occupational therapists, and social workers.



### SALARY

Physical therapy assistant ★★★★★

Physical therapist ★★★★★

### INDUSTRY PROFILE

Strong competition • Most jobs in outpatient clinics, hospitals, and schools • Growing demand for sports physical therapists and private practitioners

## AT A GLANCE



**YOUR INTERESTS** Physical therapy • Massage • Exercise • Health and social service • Sports • Biology • Anatomy • Health science • Psychology



**ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS** A doctorate in physical therapy is required, along with a commitment to ongoing education throughout your career.



**LIFESTYLE** Physical therapists typically have a normal workweek, although some clinics are open in the evening and on weekends.



**LOCATION** Most therapists work in hospitals, nursing homes, schools, and outpatient practices. Home visits are also possible.



**THE REALITIES** Treating patients over several weeks or months can be physically and mentally demanding, but rewarding when patients show improvement.

## CAREER PATHS

Physical therapists have several career options. They could work in a hospital or choose one of the specialty areas within the profession. Clinical experience in physical therapy may open up a career in hospital or health service management, or in teaching. Many physical therapists also move into private practice once they have gained extensive experience.

**ASSISTANT** You can start by assisting a qualified physical therapist while studying for your bachelor's degree.



**GRADUATE** Before practicing, you must graduate from an accredited doctoral program, pass the national physical therapy exam, and apply for a license in the state in which you want to work.

